



Debian Lenny

Brewed to Perfection

After some delay, Debian 5.0—dubbed Lenny—was finally released this Valentine's Day. How appropriate! But does it really lead to true love? There is only one way to find out...

I'm a big fan of Debian and the dedicated community involved in developing it. I make no secret of that. When I reviewed Etch (4.0) last year, I declared that if I were to finally grow up and settle down with just one distro, *this* would be the one. I like the fact that it's not backed by any commercial entity and sticks closely to its Free Software principles.

Vital stats

- Distro base: Itself; Debian is the mother of a lot of modern distros
- Packaging: *.deb* (managed by the mighty APT)
- Linux kernel: 2.6.26
- Default desktop: GNOME 2.22.1

Installation

I downloaded the Lenny network install CD image, my preferred installation method with Debian. I find it a bit wasteful to burn five full DVDs and then only use one of them. There's some merit in having everything downloaded before you start, but if you've got a reasonably fast and stable Internet connection, I recommend the network install personally. I was fortunate enough to have a chat with Steve McIntyre (the current Debian Project Leader) on a recent episode (linuxoutlaws.com/podcast/77) of Linux Outlaws, during which he told us that there are even Blu-ray images available now with everything on one disc. That sounds amazing, but not having the small fortune it requires to purchase a Blu-ray burner at the moment, it wasn't an option for me, sadly.

I booted up from the CD to get started, as always, testing it with my trusty Dell XPS m1330n laptop. I chose the graphical install and proceeded through the usual prompts for language, location and so on. On the surface, the installer looked the same to me as the Etch installer—I'd heard people raving about 'the new Debian installer', but I don't see any evidence of it. It's not necessarily a bad thing, it works well and as the old adage goes, 'If it ain't broke, don't fix it.'

I was informed pretty quickly that there were no drivers available for my Intel wireless card, but was instead offered the option to load them from a disc; I didn't have one. It wasn't a major problem since I could use the Ethernet port for the network install anyway. The base system was then installed from the CD really quickly... I mean, *lightning* quick.

All the additional packages need to be downloaded from a network mirror and you're offered the chance to pick one near you. Picking the one nearest to your location will usually result in much faster download times, so choose carefully. I picked the default UK server and was prompted to choose between installing the following package sets: Web server, mail server, DNS server, desktop, laptop and many more. I chose the desktop, laptop and standard groups, leaving all the server options alone.

The installer then informed me that I was in for a wait while it downloaded 817 packages and installed them. After this, GRUB was configured and I was ready to reboot. The whole process from putting the disc in, to booting up my new desktop, took approximately 25 minutes. That's